

1527 Babur leads his army to victory in an important battle against a confederacy of Rajput kings at Kanua.

1540 Humayun becomes a royal exile, leaving **Sher Shah Sur** as undisputed ruler of northern India.

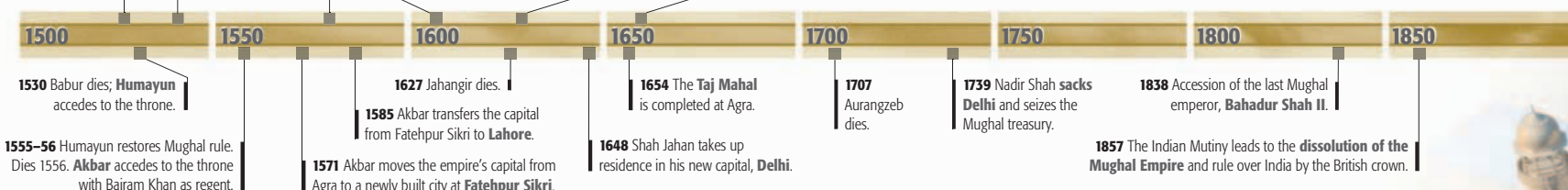
1579 Akbar abolishes the property tax on non-Muslims in an important symbolic act that implied Muslims and non-Muslims were no longer unequal within the empire.

1628 Shah Jahan accedes to the throne.

1658 Shah Jahan dies and **Aurangzeb** accedes to the throne.

THE MUGHAL DYNASTY

After an initial period of expansion and consolidation, the Mughal Empire remained a stable and vibrant entity for over 170 years (1556–1719). A long, slow decline ended with the empire's dissolution in 1857.



The first Mughal emperor

Babur, founder of the Mughal Empire, is shown here capturing sheep from the Hazara tribe. Babur is remembered as much for his literary prowess as for his military achievements. This picture is from his memoir, the *Baburnama*, which provides a frank insight into his life.

The Great Mughals

One of the most powerful states of the 17th century, the Mughal Empire had a complex administrative system that enabled it to rule over more than 100 million people across most of the Indian subcontinent. The splendor and sophistication of its court was world-famous.

The decisive battles in Babur's (see left) conquest of north India were his defeat of the Afghan Sultan of Delhi, Ibrahim Lodi, at Panipat in 1526 and his success over a confederacy of Rajput kings at Kanua the following year. Using firearms and an experienced and efficient cavalry, he had consolidated Mughal (Persian for Mongol) rule over the rich cities and

productive lands of northern India from his capital at Agra by his death in 1530.

His son, Humayun, met with less success. By 1540, he had lost his father's kingdom to the Afghan ruler, Sher Shah Sur, and had been forced into exile at the Safavid court in Persia. In mid-1555, with Persian support, he restored Mughal rule by defeating Sher Shah's weaker descendants, thus

duplicating his father's conquests. However, he died just seven months later, leaving the empire to his 12-year-old son, Akbar, with an influential noble, Bairam Khan, as his regent.

Together, they extended Mughal control over northern India, in the region bounded by the Indus and Ganges rivers, to form an imperial heartland that, in time, was framed by palace fortresses at Agra, Allahabad, Ajmer, and Lahore. After he came of age in 1560, Akbar achieved a further series of military successes; by his death in 1605, his empire reached from Kashmir in the north and Afghanistan in the northwest, to Bengal in the east and the Deccan plateau in the south.

Structure and tolerance

To consolidate his position, Akbar established a centralized system of government. This was administered by warrior-aristocrats (*mansabdars*) of various ranks who could be appointed to bureaucratic or military positions and were accompanied by their own households or troops. The most senior *mansabdars* were paid with land grants (*jagirs*). They had the right to collect taxes from this land, but could not own, govern, or occupy it.

Akbar had a policy of religious tolerance, which was evident in his own marriages to women of different faiths, whom he did not force to convert to Islam. This was a shrewd

BEFORE

On the eve of its conquest by the Muslim Mughals, India was very fragmented.

MUSLIM AND HINDU INDIA

Muslim rule over India's predominantly Hindu population began in the north with the **Delhi Sultanate** (1206–1526) << 180–81. The south was dominated by the Hindu **Vijayanagar Empire**. The center consisted mainly of Muslim sultanates, while the **Hindu Rajputs** and **Lodi Afghans** quarreled over the north.

BABUR IN AFGHANISTAN

To the northwest, in Central Asia, **Babur**, a descendant of Genghis Khan << 164–65, had been exiled from his home in Ferghana by the Uzbek Shaibani Khan. He seized Kabul, capital of Afghanistan in 1504, then moved on to India.

